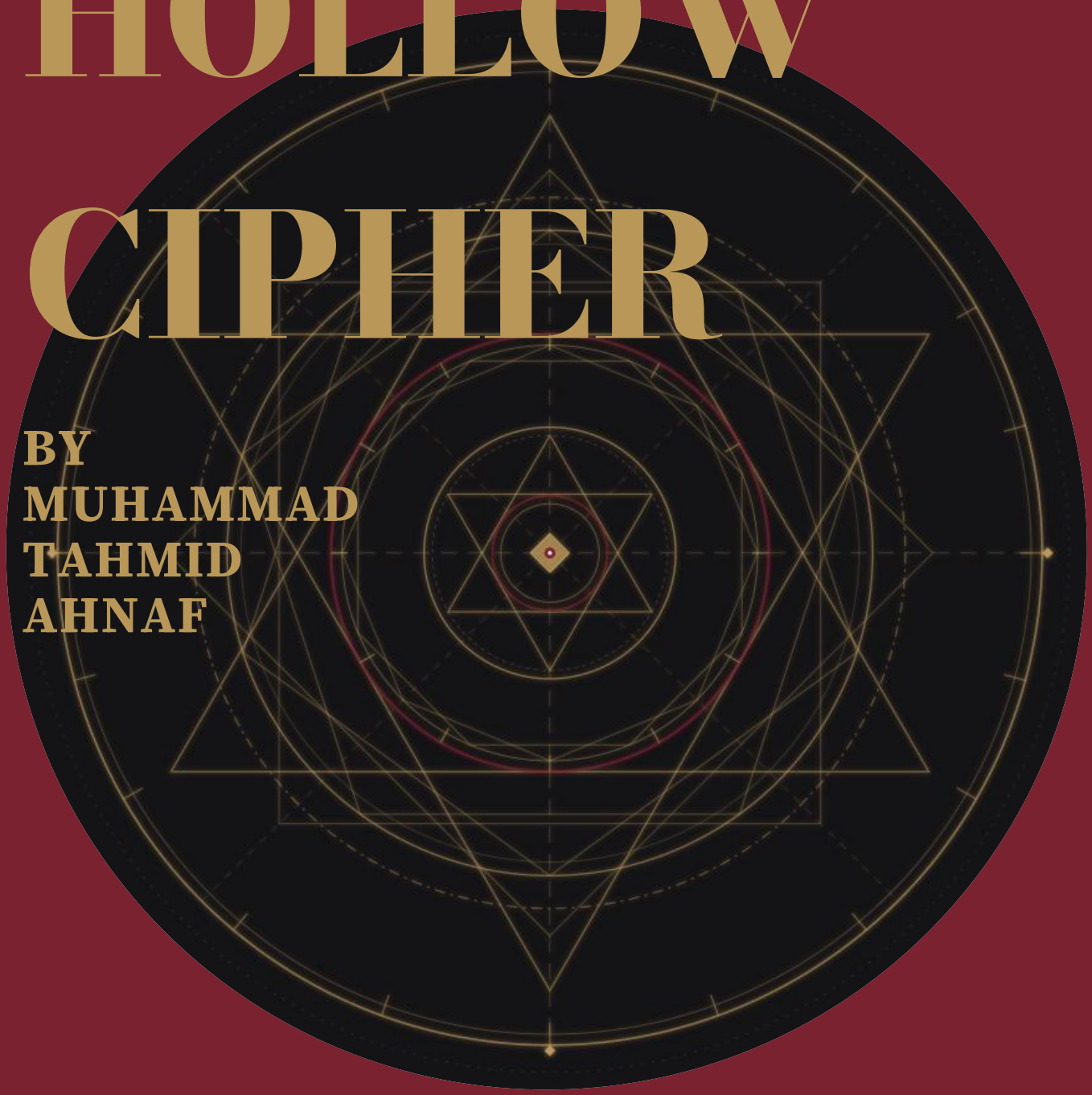
THE HOLLOW CIPHER



BY
MUHAMMAD
TAHMID
AHNAF

LEVEL 4

THE MAN WHO DEVELOPED THE DARK

[Level 4; Case: The Man Who Developed The Dark]

[Time] 1st December, 1887 | 11:30 AM

[Location] The Palassy Ground, Dhaka

[Statement]

The wall beneath the eastern wing did not break like ordinary masonry. When the investigators finally opened it, the bricks came away from the inside, one by one, as though someone had been patiently removing them for years. Behind them lay a narrow passage that descended beneath the newspaper archive. The air smelled of wet earth, burnt chemicals, and something faintly sweet that had no business surviving underground.

The chamber at its end was far larger than the building above could have permitted. Its walls were covered with maps of Bengal, each marked with black pins, red threads, and small photographs of people who had never met one another. Dhaka, Chittagong, Rajshahi, Sylhet, Mymensingh, and towns beyond the reach of the newspaper's circulation had all been marked. Beside each location were names, dates, and descriptions of incidents that had not yet occurred. A village fire. A child who would speak in an unfamiliar voice. A magistrate found kneeling before a mirror. A family that would disappear from a locked house, leaving every door secured from within.

At first, the investigator assumed the documents described predictions. Then the first report was found beneath a photograph of a house that had not yet burned. The report described the fire in the past tense. It named the dead, described the position of their bodies, and recorded the testimony of a witness who would not be born for another six years. Every page bore the same mark: an eye enclosed within a rhombus, crossed through as though someone had tried to destroy it and failed.

The documents revealed the actual ambition of the Evil Eye's Wrath. It was no isolated circle of frightened men whispering over forbidden books. It was an organisation preparing to spread across the nation, using staged miracles, disappearances, blackmail, and carefully arranged deaths to make the population believe that an invisible power had begun judging the living. Its followers would create the terror, then offer protection from it. Its enemies would become examples. Its believers would become informants. Its

victims would become martyrs. In every district, fear would be given a different face, but every face would look toward the same Eye.

Then the investigator found the photographs.

Arif Rahman stood beside a window in his study, alive and apparently unaware that he was being photographed. Arindom Kumar Biswas sat at his desk with his hands folded, his eyes open. Jawer Chakrovarty appeared in a room whose walls were covered with the cult's symbol. The three photographs had been taken on different dates, in different places, under different lighting. Yet each man had a dark circle beneath his feet, like the shadow cast by an object that was not present.

The fourth photograph showed the investigator entering the chamber.

It had been taken from behind.

There was no second entrance. No window. No opening through which a photographer could have watched the passage. The plate was still damp, and the image continued to darken while the investigator held it. In the photograph, the investigator was carrying the notebook recovered from Jawer. In reality, the notebook remained locked in the archive above.

The investigator turned the plate over.

Written on its reverse was a sentence in the same handwriting as the anonymous message:

YOU WERE NOT FOLLOWING THE EVIDENCE. THE EVIDENCE WAS FOLLOWING YOU.

A sound came from the far end of the chamber. Three slow knocks.

The investigator raised the lantern.

At the end of the room stood a tall photographic screen, its black cloth hanging motionless in the still air. A human silhouette was visible behind it. The figure did not move when addressed. It did not move when approached. Only when the investigator stepped to one side did the silhouette appear to turn its head.

There was no one behind the screen.

On the table beside it lay a freshly developed photograph of the investigator standing exactly where they stood now, holding the lantern in the same hand, looking toward the same empty screen.

The photograph had captured the next moment as well.

In it, the investigator's mouth was open, screaming.

[Question]

Who orchestrated the nationwide conspiracy?

[Evidences]

[The National Ledger]

The ledger is bound in black leather and contains hundreds of entries arranged by district rather than by date. Each entry identifies a local intermediary, a planned incident, the rumour to be spread afterward, and the person responsible for ensuring that the rumour reached the public.

The incidents were designed to appear unrelated. In one town, a series of deaths would be blamed on a cursed well. In another, a child would survive an illness after a stranger placed a black stone beneath the bed. Elsewhere, a judge would receive letters describing private acts he had never confessed. The details differed, but the method was identical. First came an inexplicable event. Then came a witness. Then came a story. Finally, someone appeared who claimed to understand the meaning of the event and offered protection from its repetition.

The ledger records payments to printers, travelling photographers, apothecaries, private guards, and men who delivered sealed envelopes without asking what they contained. Several payments were disguised as fees for portraits and documentary work. Others were recorded as expenses for the newspaper archive.

The most disturbing entries are not those that describe successful operations. They are the entries marked with a small, empty circle. Those locations were never crossed out, abandoned, or declared unsuccessful. They were marked as *already begun*.

The same mark appears beside the archive itself.

At the end of the ledger is a list of names. Some belong to known members of the Evil Eye's Wrath. Others belong to people who publicly denounced the cult. A few belong to people who died before the ledger was supposedly created. The final name is the investigator's.

Beside it is a single instruction.

DO NOT RECRUIT. LET THE INVESTIGATION DO IT.

[The Three Curses]

A separate document describes the fates of Arif, Arindom, and Jawer. It does not call them murders, punishments, or accidents. It calls them *corrections*.

Arif Rahman discovered that the Evil Eye's Wrath was manufacturing the evidence that sustained its influence. He believed the notebook would expose the network. The document records that he was to be silenced before he could publish his findings. His death on 5 October 1887 was made to resemble an ordinary violent crime, concealing the poison that actually killed him. The knife wound was a message for the living, not the cause of death.

Arindom Kumar Biswas helped suppress the investigation and believed that his cooperation would spare him from the consequences. After his arrest, he died in custody

with his eyes torn out and his body arranged in a posture resembling prayer. The document states that he had asked the Eye to hide him from what he had done. His eyes were taken not simply as mutilation, but as a final answer to that request.

Jawer Chakrovarty stole the notebook because he believed its contents could make him indispensable to the cult. His name appears beside a phrase written in a different hand: *He who steals the key shall become its lock.* Jawer had not merely taken evidence. He had accepted a ritual obligation that made the stolen notebook part of his own punishment.

The document contains no explanation of how the curses were carried out. Some instructions are practical. Others describe events that should be impossible. One passage orders a witness to be present in two places on the same night. Another records that a man will remember a death before the victim has been chosen.

At the bottom of the page, beneath the three names, is a fourth space.

The investigator's name has been written there, then carefully scratched away.

The pressure of the writing remains visible.

[The Photographer's Archive]

The photographic plates were catalogued by date, location, subject, and exposure. Many show ordinary scenes: newspaper offices, street vendors, courtrooms, private gatherings, and portraits of people who had no apparent connection to the cult.

When arranged by the time of exposure, however, the photographs reveal a pattern. The same man appears at the edge of events across several years. Sometimes he is standing beside a window. Sometimes he is reflected in a polished surface. Sometimes he is hidden among a crowd, his camera raised toward a subject no one else appears to notice.

The man is Mahir Hossain.

In one photograph, Mahir stands outside Arif's study on the night of the murder. In another, he is reflected in the glass behind Arindom's desk. In a third, he appears at the edge of the gathering where Jawer first encountered the symbol of the crossed eye. The images establish that Mahir had access to all three men, but the details are stranger than simple proximity can explain.

The plate from Arif's study shows Mahir holding a camera with a cracked lens. The plate from Arindom's office shows the same camera, with the same crack, although the photograph is dated four months earlier. The plate associated with Jawer shows the camera reflected in a mirror, but the reflection contains no photographer.

The final plate in the collection has no date. It shows Mahir standing alone before a blank wall. His camera is pointed directly at the viewer. Behind him, written in the dust, are the words:

THE FIRST WITNESS WAS NEVER ARIF.

The phrase matches the message that appeared beside the pendant.

Beneath it, almost invisible, is a second sentence:

HE WAS ONLY THE FIRST WITNESS YOU WERE GIVEN.

[The Anonymous Letter]

The anonymous letter was not delivered through the newspaper's usual correspondence system. Its paper came from a batch purchased by Mahir for photographic records. The ink contains traces of a chemical solution used in his studio. The handwriting imitates the investigator's, including a distinctive break in the final stroke of certain letters.

The letter's wording was designed to lead the investigator toward Durjo, then away from him, then toward the notebook, and finally toward the hidden chamber. Its statements were carefully chosen. Some were true. Some were technically true but deliberately misleading. Others described events that had not yet occurred when the letter was supposedly written.

A note in Mahir's private register refers to the letter as *the first exposure*.

The next entry reads:

The investigator must believe the discovery is their own. A guided hand leaves fingerprints. An awakened suspicion leaves a trail.

The letter was not sent to prevent a crime. It was sent to produce a particular investigation, with particular discoveries, in a particular order.

But the final paragraph does not appear in the surviving copy. It is present only as an impression on the page beneath it, as though the words were written on a sheet that no longer exists.

The impression reads:

WHEN THE INVESTIGATOR REACHES THE CHAMBER, THE CHAMBER WILL HAVE ALREADY REACHED THE INVESTIGATOR.

[The Blank Notebook]

The notebook recovered from Jawer appears empty. Under angled light, however, its pages reveal impressions that correspond to the symbols in the national ledger. The marks are not a simple substitution cipher. Their positions change depending on which page is placed beneath them, as if the notebook were designed to be read through the pressure left by another document.

The impressions reveal routes between the cult's local cells, names of intermediaries, and dates associated with staged incidents. They also contain references to photographs that have not been found.

One sequence ends with three dates: 5 October, the day Arif died; the date of Arindom's death in custody; and 14 October, the date written beside the investigator's claim to have killed Jawer.

The sequence does not identify the dates as past or future. Instead, it marks each with the same symbol used for an exposure that has not yet developed.

The final page bears a sentence in the investigator's handwriting:

I KILLED JAWER CHAKROVARTY ON THE FOURTEENTH OF OCTOBER, 1887.

No body has been recovered. No witness has confirmed the killing. The investigator cannot remember committing it.

The sentence is not written in the same ink as the other impressions. It is fresh.

When the notebook is closed, a faint sound comes from within it: the slow, deliberate click of a camera shutter.

[The Unfinished Photograph]

A glass plate found inside a locked drawer depicts the hidden chamber from an angle that should be physically impossible. It shows the national ledger, the photographic apparatus, the empty chair, and the investigator standing with their back to the camera.

The plate also shows Mahir.

He stands on the opposite side of the room, facing the investigator. His expression is calm. One hand rests on the investigator's shoulder.

The investigator was alone when the plate was discovered.

The plate's date is 14 October 1887, but the chemical development marks indicate that it was prepared before that day. The plate is labelled with a name that has been scraped away. Under magnification, the remaining letters resemble the investigator's name.

The most disturbing detail appears only when the plate is held before a flame. The room remains visible, but the figures vanish. In their place are dark outlines of the same people, standing in positions that do not match their bodies in the original image.

Mahir's outline is facing the wall.

The investigator's outline is facing the camera.

And the empty chair has a shadow.

[Interrogation]

[Durjo Das]

Durjo appears exhausted. He has spent the night reading the recovered ledger, and the pages have left black stains across his fingers.

Investigator: You knew Arif was close to exposing the cult.

Durjo: I knew he had found a pattern. I did not know the pattern had found him first.

Investigator: Did Mahir know what Arif was investigating?

Durjo: Mahir photographed the evidence before Arif finished collecting it. Once, Arif showed me a photograph of a document he had not yet written. He thought someone had forged it to frighten him.

Investigator: And you?

Durjo: I told him to burn it. He asked me how you burn a thing that has not happened yet.

Durjo looks at the notebook.

Durjo: Arif began to believe the investigation was being written around him. Every time he changed direction, another clue appeared. Every time he rejected a theory, a new piece of evidence made it seem possible again. He thought he was outsmarting someone. Then he began to suspect that his mistakes were the only things the other person needed.

Investigator: Why did you not tell me this before?

Durjo: Because I was afraid you would recognise the feeling.

[Mahir Hossain]

Mahir enters without a camera. His hands are clean, his cuffs immaculate. He looks at the ledger, the photographs, and the notebook without asking how they were recovered.

Investigator: The plates place you at the scenes involving Arif, Arindom, and Jawer. The ledger connects you to the cult's national operation. The anonymous letter came from your studio.

Mahir: Then you have found a great deal.

Investigator: You sent the letter.

Mahir: Yes.

Investigator: You directed the investigation.

Mahir: I arranged its light.

Investigator: You orchestrated the Evil Eye's Wrath.

Mahir: I gave men who were already hungry a table at which to eat. Some wanted wealth. Some wanted revenge. Some wanted to be feared. Some wanted to believe that their cruelty served something greater than themselves. I gave each of them a story that made their desires feel inevitable.

Investigator: You staged the miracles.

Mahir: Some of them.

Investigator: And the rest?

Mahir looks toward the sealed wall.

Mahir: You have seen enough to know that not every photograph can be explained by the person holding the camera.

Investigator: Arif died because he found your operation.

Mahir: Arif died because he believed truth would make him untouchable. He found the mechanism, but he mistook understanding it for escaping it.

Investigator: Arindom helped you.

Mahir: Arindom helped himself. He thought the Eye was a weapon he could put down when the room became dangerous. When he tried to withdraw, he discovered that the weapon had already learned his name.

Investigator: And Jawer?

Mahir's expression changes. It is the first time he appears genuinely interested.

Mahir: Jawer wanted the notebook. He thought it contained a secret he could steal. He never understood that the secret was not inside the book. It was in the person who believed the book belonged to them.

Investigator: Did you kill Jawer?

Mahir: You have written that you did.

Investigator: I did not write it.

Mahir: Then you have a more serious problem than murder.

Mahir leans forward.

Mahir: Tell me, investigator. When you found the first clue, did you feel relief? When you found the second, did you feel clever? When the evidence contradicted you, did you abandon your theory or search for a more complicated one that would preserve it?

Investigator: What are you suggesting?

Mahir: That a person can be led by the nose without ever being forced to move. That a prisoner can mistake the walls of their cell for the boundaries of the world. That a man can follow a trail of truths and arrive at a lie he would defend with his life.

Investigator: You made me do this.

Mahir: No. I made certain you would want to.

Mahir glances at the blank notebook.

Mahir: The worst thing I ever learned about people is that they do not need to be deceived about everything. Give them enough truth, and they will defend the lie themselves.

Investigator: Why me?

Mahir does not answer immediately. He looks past the investigator, toward a point just above the left shoulder.

Mahir: Because you kept asking who had done it. You never asked why the evidence wanted you to know.

Investigator: What does that mean?

Mahir: Look at the photographs again. Not at the faces. At the shadows.

The investigator turns toward the table.

When they look back, Mahir is still seated, but his eyes are closed. The guard outside the room insists that no one has entered or left. Mahir opens his eyes and asks why the investigator has been standing alone in the room for so long.

He denies that the conversation has occurred.

The transcript is already in the investigator's casebook.

[The Chamber After the Confession]

The investigator returns to the hidden chamber after midnight. The ledger remains open to the page containing the investigator's name. The final instruction has changed.

The original words, *Do not recruit. Let the investigation do it*, have been crossed out.

Beneath them is written:

THE INVESTIGATOR HAS ARRIVED. THE RECRUITMENT IS COMPLETE.

The investigator searches the chamber for a hidden writer, a concealed mechanism, or a second passage. There is nothing. The walls are solid. The door is locked from the inside. The lantern burns steadily.

Then the investigator notices that the photographs on the wall have changed.

Arif's portrait is no longer taken from the side. He is looking directly at the camera. Arindom's eyes are no longer open. Jawer's hands are empty. The photograph of Mahir shows him standing behind the investigator, but the figure in the foreground is now facing the wall.

The investigator removes the photograph and turns it over.

A new sentence has appeared beneath the old one:

YOU ARE LOOKING AT THE WRONG SIDE.

The investigator turns the photograph toward the light.

For an instant, the image shows a different room: the newspaper office, years earlier. Arif is seated at his desk. Mahir stands beside him, holding a camera. Between them sits a young figure whose face has been scratched away.

The investigator recognises the room.

They recognise the desk.

They recognise the handwriting on the papers.

They cannot explain why the figure without a face is wearing their own clothes.

A knock sounds from behind the wall.

Then another.

Then a third.

The investigator presses an ear to the bricks.

A voice from the other side whispers:

“You have found him.”

The investigator steps back.

The voice continues.

“Now tell me who found you.”

[Past History]

[Arif Rahman]

Arif was a journalist who investigated the disappearances and unnatural incidents attributed to the Evil Eye's Wrath. He uncovered evidence that many of the incidents were manufactured to encourage fear and recruit followers. His investigation also brought him into contact with records that appeared to describe events before they happened.

Arif died on 5 October 1887. His death was presented as a violent attack, but poison was the actual cause. The knife wound was part of the scene arranged around his death. The notebook he sought contained evidence connecting the newspaper archive to the cult's expanding network.

[Arindom Kumar Biswas]

Arindom was the newspaper's chief editor and a participant in the cover up surrounding Arif's investigation. He believed his cooperation would protect his position and spare him from the cult's retaliation. His death in custody, with his eyes torn out and his body arranged in a posture resembling prayer, followed his attempt to escape the obligations he had accepted.

The chamber ledger describes his fate as a correction. It does not explain whether the mutilation was carried out by a person, a ritual, or something the cult itself did not fully understand.

[Jawer Chakrovarty]

Jawer stole the notebook and concealed his involvement with a subgroup of the Evil Eye's Wrath. He believed that possessing the notebook would give him power over the people whose names it contained. Instead, the theft made him a custodian of evidence he could neither understand nor safely surrender.

The investigator's casebook contains a statement claiming that Jawer was killed on 14 October 1887. No body or independent witness confirms the event. The date is also the date attached to the unfinished photograph and several entries in the chamber ledger.

[Mahir Hossain]

Mahir was the photographer associated with the newspaper's investigations. His work gave him access to the subjects, locations, and private records that later appeared in the cult's archive. The recovered plates and ledger establish that he coordinated the staging of incidents, the distribution of evidence, and the recruitment methods used by the Evil Eye's Wrath.

Mahir understood the power of an image. A photograph could establish that a person had been present, suggest that a meeting had occurred, or create the appearance of an event that no witness remembered. He used that trust to make the cult's influence appear larger, older, and more inevitable than any ordinary organisation could have been.

The evidence identifies him as the human architect of the conspiracy. It does not establish that he controlled every event associated with it.

[The Evil Eye's Wrath]

The Evil Eye's Wrath sought to establish a nationwide cult by turning fear into authority. Its organisers planned incidents that would appear supernatural, circulated stories that gave those incidents meaning, and offered protection to those frightened by the results. Local cells would appear independent while sharing symbols, instructions, and methods.

Arif's investigation threatened to expose the operation. Arindom's complicity helped conceal it. Jawer's theft complicated the chain of evidence and tied him more deeply to the group. Their fates were recorded as consequences of the same covenant, although the full nature of that covenant remains uncertain.

Some evidence points to deliberate human manipulation. Other evidence resists any explanation based solely on deception. The cult may have exploited belief in a supernatural power, but the chamber records suggest that its members encountered something they could not entirely command.

[Solution]

Mahir Hossain

[Explanation]

Mahir Hossain orchestrated the nationwide conspiracy behind the Evil Eye's Wrath. The national ledger documents a coordinated network of local operations. The photographic plates place Mahir at the centre of the events surrounding Arif, Arindom, and Jawer. The anonymous message was produced using materials from his studio and was deliberately constructed to guide the investigator toward selected discoveries. Mahir's own statements confirm that he shaped the investigation and manipulated the fears and ambitions of the cult's members.

The curses were not separate mysteries. They were consequences of the same chain of events. Arif was silenced when his investigation threatened to expose the conspiracy. Arindom's attempt to conceal his complicity did not free him from its consequences. Jawer's theft bound him to the secret he hoped to possess. Each man believed he could control one part of the situation. Each discovered that his choices had already become part of something larger.

Mahir's method depended on more than lying. He used true evidence to guide false conclusions, staged events to reinforce genuine fears, and made the investigator believe that every discovery was an independent victory. The anonymous message was not a warning. It was the first step in a carefully arranged investigation.

Yet the final evidence prevents the case from closing cleanly. The impossible photographs, the future dated records, and the investigator's unexplained handwriting cannot be dismissed as ordinary tricks. Mahir may have exploited these phenomena, but the evidence does not prove that he created them. His confession establishes his responsibility for the conspiracy, not his mastery over everything that occurred within it.

As the investigator prepares to leave the archive, a final photographic plate appears beneath the locked door. It shows the national ledger burning in the chamber. Every page has turned to ash except the one bearing the investigator's name.

On the reverse is a final message:

THE EYE HAS BEEN FOUND. THE EYE HAS BEEN NAMED. THE EYE HAS BEEN GIVEN A FACE.

Beneath it, in handwriting the investigator recognises as their own, is one last sentence:

NOW IT CAN LOOK THROUGH YOU.